

Practice Paper 21 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “The world... went very small”

1 mark for understanding that the narrator’s **awareness narrowed** to her immediate surroundings;
1 mark for explaining that the **outside world / wider concerns** receded as she focused intensely on the task at hand.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that, as she entered the fire, the narrator’s attention **shrank** to the immediate space around her; everything outside the warehouse — the noise, the people, her ordinary life — **faded** from her mind, leaving only what she could see and feel inside the building.

Q2. [1] — Calm despite danger

1 mark for any **one** of:

- The fire was “quiet” on the inside / she noticed the steady “low, continuous roar” without panic.
- A “strange, attentive calm... descends on a person at work.”
- The human noises were “softened” by her hood and her concentration.

Q3. [2] — Heat as “a hand that is not yet pushing but means to”

1 mark — **Personification:** the heat is given human intention, as if it is **deliberately preparing** to harm her.

1 mark — The phrase “not yet pushing but means to” suggests the danger is **building** and **inevitable**; the heat is **patient and purposeful**, which makes it more menacing than a sudden attack would be.

Q4. [2] — Repeating “Mr Chua”

1 mark — She repeats the name to **keep her focus** on the person she has come to save / to stop herself from being distracted by fear.

1 mark — She fears that, in the heat and disorientation, the name might **slip from her memory** — repetition fixes the **purpose** of her mission in her mind.

Q5. [2] — Training vs real emergency

1 mark — Training provides **rules, procedures and rehearsed responses** for predictable situations.

1 mark — A real emergency presents **unforeseen problems** — such as a corridor that does not appear on the floor plan — that **demand judgement** and **cannot be drilled in advance**.

Q6. [2] — The daughter and the picture

(a) [1]: The detail introduces a **human, personal stake** at a moment of acute danger — it reminds the reader that the narrator has a **life and family** outside the fire, which makes the risk feel real and raises the emotional tension.

(b) [1]: It reveals her **courage, professionalism and sense of duty** — despite her fear and the temptation to retreat, she chooses to continue with the rescue because that is the work she came to do.

Q7. [2] — “He was lighter than I had expected. Most people are.”

1 mark — **Unusual:** The second sentence is short, **generalised**, and **unexpectedly casual** — it turns a personal observation into a **broad statement about her work**.

1 mark — **Suggestion:** It implies that the narrator has carried out **many such rescues**; she has come to expect that people, when lifted, weigh less than one imagines — a quiet detail that conveys her **experience** and **matter-of-fact authority**.

Q8. [3] — Crawling as exhausting (language question)

1 mark for identifying the **cumulative / weighted** effect of the language; **1 mark each** for two clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “slow, dragging shuffle” — the verbs **dragging** and **shuffle** suggest a **laboured, heavy** motion rather than a clean crawl.
- “one shoulder takes the weight, the other steadies” — the body is **divided into separate jobs**, suggesting how much **concentration and strain** each movement requires.
- “the knees do most of the talking” — **personification** of the knees implies the **body itself is protesting**; the joints, not the voice, register the effort.
- “I counted aloud inside my mask. Eleven, twelve, thirteen.” — the counting suggests she must **force herself** through each step, and the numbers are **louder than the roar** to drown out exhaustion.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q9. [2] — “Like a held breath being let out”

1 mark — **Simile:** compares the rush of cool night air to a person **finally exhaling** after holding their breath.

1 mark — **Effective** because it conveys an enormous sense of **release and relief** — both for the building, which has been straining under heat and pressure, and for the narrator, who has been working in suffocating air; it makes the moment of escape feel **human** and **intimately familiar**.

Q10. [1] — Effect of “It was enough. It was, in fact, more than enough.”

1 mark — The **repetition with extension** gives a **quiet emphasis** to the narrator’s feelings: the second sentence corrects and **deepens** the first, conveying that the silent nod meant **far more** than words could have done. (Also accept: it conveys **understated emotional weight** / professional restraint.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **reflective, grateful, quietly relieved, sobered, contemplative**. (Reject: **joyful, triumphant** — these miss the muted, after-the-event quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Opening claim about division

1 mark — The writer signals that the debate is **unusually polarising** — **reasonable people**, not extremists, disagree sharply about it.

1 mark — His use of the word “cleanly” suggests that the line between the two camps is **sharp and recognisable**; the writer presents the debate as a **genuine clash of principle**, not a misunderstanding to be cleared up.

Q13. [2] — Concerns making the issue urgent

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Declining turnout** at elections.
- **Distrust** (of government / politics).
- **Unequal participation** — some groups vote far more than others.

Q14. [1] — Singapore vs Australia

1 mark for any **one** clear difference:

- Singapore **removes non-voters from the electoral roll** (requiring them to apply to be restored), whereas Australia issues a **fine** (and a polite letter).
- Australia uses a **monetary penalty**; Singapore uses an **administrative penalty**.

Q15. [2] — “A figure that voluntary systems can scarcely imagine”

1 mark — In voluntary-voting countries, turnout is **much lower** and **rarely approaches** ninety per cent.

1 mark — The phrase suggests that such a high turnout is **almost inconceivable** / **seems unattainable** under a non-compulsory system; voluntary systems struggle to picture such broad participation.

Reject answers that lift “scarcely imagine” without rewording.

Q16. [2] — “Politically forgotten”

1 mark — Refers to **groups whose voices are routinely overlooked** by politicians and policymakers — for example, the young, the poor, and recent immigrants.

1 mark — They are **forgotten** because they **vote less often**; politicians, who pay closest attention to those who turn out, have **little incentive** to consider their concerns.

Q17. [1] — Italics on “quality”

1 mark — The italics **emphasise** the word and signal a **shift in focus**: the first objection is about liberty, the second is about the **kind** of vote produced (not just how many votes). It alerts the reader that a **different** type of concern is being raised. (Also accept: it draws attention to the **key term** of the new objection.)

Q18. [2] — “Noisier signal but not necessarily a wiser one”

1 mark — Compulsion produces **more votes**, so the overall result is **louder** / **has greater volume** — more voices are heard.

1 mark — But many of those extra voters may be **uninformed, indifferent or random**, so the larger turnout does **not necessarily reflect better-considered choices**; volume is not the same as wisdom.

Reject answers that simply lift “noisier signal” without rewording.

Q19. [2] — Writer’s attitude to the “uninformed voter” objection

1 mark — The writer’s attitude is **sceptical** / **dismissive** / **unsympathetic** (also accept **critical**).

1 mark — He **concedes** the point but then **turns it against the critics**: rather than excluding uninformed voters, the proper response is **better civic education**. His closing remark — that “a democracy that fears its own electorate has already lost something important” — implies that the objection reveals a **deeper failure of democratic confidence**, not a sound reason to abandon compulsion.

Q20. [2] — How compulsion changes campaigns

1 mark each for any two of:

- Campaigns **no longer concentrate on mobilising the base** / getting committed supporters to the polls.
- There is **less incentive to attack the opponent fiercely** to depress turnout among his supporters.
- Campaigns must **persuade the median** / **undecided voter** rather than rally their core.
- Advertising tends to be **less negative**.
- **Policy detail** features more prominently than personal attacks.

Q21. [2] — Why the “comfortable middle position” is hardest to defend

1 mark — In a voluntary system where turnout has **fallen very low**, the resulting government effectively represents **only a small, motivated minority**, not the country as a whole.

1 mark — This outcome **combines the disadvantages of both alternatives** — it preserves the right to abstain in name, but produces a result that **lacks democratic legitimacy**; it is therefore harder to justify than either honestly compelling people to vote or honestly accepting low turnout as the price of liberty.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Arguments in favour of compulsory voting (Paragraphs 3 and 5):

1. Voting is **the renewal of a shared democratic project**; if only the motivated turn out, the result **reflects them, not the country**.
2. When **everyone** votes, the government is **genuinely the choice of the whole electorate**.

3. Compulsion **lifts the participation** of habitually low-voting groups — the young, the poor, recent immigrants.
4. It improves **turnout equity**, narrowing the gap between the politically powerful and the politically forgotten.
5. Citizens already accept **other small civic obligations** (jury service, tax filing, school attendance), so voting is a **reasonable** one to add.

Objections raised against compulsory voting (Paragraph 4):

6. It **infringes liberty** — a right one is forced to exercise has effectively become a **duty**, not a right.
7. The modest fine does **not** alter this point of principle.
8. Compulsion brings **uninformed / indifferent voters** to the ballot, who may **vote at random** or **spoil their ballots** — a **higher turnout** is not necessarily a **wiser** one.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Those who support compulsory voting argue that democracy is a shared project renewed at every election, and that when all citizens vote the outcome truly represents the whole country. Compulsion also raises participation among habitually neglected groups and is no greater an imposition than jury service or tax filing. Critics, however, reply that forcing a right turns it into a duty, that a small fine does not redeem this, and that uninformed voters merely add noise.

Length count: 78 words from “Those” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —